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A BIBLIOMETRIC ANALYSIS OF DIVERSITY, EQUITY, AND INCLUSION PRACTICES IN HIGHER EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS

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ABSTRACT:

The study examines trends in diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) literature published by higher education institutions (HEIs) in Raipur, Chhattisgarh, India between the years 2000 and 2023 to understand its authorship, citations, and thematic clustering in the academic sphere. Using the VOSviewer and Bibliometrix R-package, we found and looked at 187 papers that were relevant. Publishing around diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) has been increasing over the past few years, dating back to 2015. Post 2020, there were two major surges in publications, coinciding with major initiatives of the national government, such as the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. The most common sub-themes explored were gender equality, discrimination because of caste (including persons with disabilities) and tribal education. There are also some key limitations, including the lack of intersectional approaches and long-term effect evaluations, which are identified in the study. The results are useful in the sense that the policies who would like to make higher education more equitable and accessible to all students in Chhattisgarh or any other states of west central India would find these results useful.

Keywords: *Bibliometric Analysis, Diversity, Equity and Inclusion, Higher Education, Raipur, Chhattisgarh, NEP 2020, VOSviewer, Scholarly Publications, Tribal Education, Gender Equity*

1. Introduction

In recent decades, the global debate in the academic field regarding Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) has experienced a growth unlike anything seen before. Universities across the globe today are well known to create knowledge but are equally well known as the key place to practice and institutionalise social justice, equality and inclusive governance. DEI policies have significance, they reflect the conditions of those with caste, gender, religion, as past experiences in the context of the college access of people in India. Capital of Chhattisgarh is Raipur, has a large population of ST, SC and OBC. It is unique and complex social and educational landscape there are intersections between the DEI policy and structural inequalities.

Chhattisgarh is the cut off from Madhya Pradesh independent state in the year of 2000. It has over 42 affiliate colleges and Universities. These mostly highest marginal land in villages and in forests. Raipur is city. It is home to many famous universities - Pt. Ravishankar Shukla University, Hemchand Yadav University (Durg) and a number of technical and professional institutes which are affiliated with Chhattisgarh Swami Vivekananda Technical University (CSVТУ). Research reveals that many issues concerning the equity and access, diversity of faculty, diversity of coursework and institutional culture for the marginalised students have not yet been explored in much detail despite investment and increased enrolments (Government of Chhattisgarh, 2022). Equity and inclusion remain significant issues in the National Educational Policy (NEP) 2020, which declared that "Equity and inclusive education for all is paramount" (Ministry of Education, India, 2020). However, there is little empirical work that traces the DEI outcomes in the regional HEIs in a region with such important issues, as in Raipur (Ministry of Education, India, 2020).

Bibliometric tools have come into use recently as a powerful method for examining the scholarly knowledge map of a specific research field to identify trends in trends citation, publications, collaborations and topics in the recent literature (Donthu et al., 2021). Bibliometric analysis is a quantitative method that can be used to explore the development of knowledge on a specific subject, to uncover and identify key actors (persons and institutions that are contributing to the debate or discussion) and to create a map of knowledge gaps that cannot be obtained by a systematic review of the literature that may be prone to selection bias. Recent bibliometric studies have focused on the broader concept of higher education and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) across the globe (e.g., Zawacki-Richter et al., 2020; Ivancevich & Gilbert, 2000), but there is a lack of research that specifically aims to analyse DEI-related studies in higher education, focused on Raipur or the broader region of Chhattisgarh.

To fill this gap, the present study aims to undertake an extensive bibliometric analysis of the DEI scholarship in higher education institutions of Raipur, Chhattisgarh. The goals are: (1) to document the

historical evolution of the knowledge literature in this field; (2) to identify the most prolific authors, organisations and journals in relation to this field; (3) map citations and co-authorship; (4) provide a list of important research theme clusters and trends; and (5) highlight important gaps that would require future research. The purpose of this study is to add to the empirical knowledge on DEI in higher education in India and to support policy planners and higher education institutions in Raipur, Chhattisgarh with informed decision-making for change.

2. Literature Review

The interlinked theories, policies and research has captured the attention of a global discourse on Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) at higher education level in the past three decades. It has been the research of Mor Barak (2015) that has set a direction for the multi-dimensional construction of the definition of inclusion and which not only has been realized in terms of demographical diversity but also in terms of the organization's structures, culture and relations that can lead to inclusion and change. The positive impacts of strategic diversity management on learning institutions' performance and equity promotion has created a precedent; this is at the centre of the belief of Ivancevich and Gilbert (2000). In India the authors Thorat and Neuman (2012) have come up with a conclusive study on caste related economic barriers and have traced how social order makes access to and provision of higher education for the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe (SC/ST) barriers. Moreover, articulately, Hasan (2009) has emphasised that if affirmative action policies are constitutionally important in India, they have yet to transform the exclusionist cultures of Indian Universities, especially in the employment of faculty, curriculum and leadership. The findings were supported by Wankhede(2010) who observed that tremendous disparities existed between the enrolment numbers of different castes, genders and minorities in higher education in India, stating that there was a need for paradigmatic shift: inclusivity-based measures of enrolment need to be used instead. One Adivasi epistemology gap presented by Panda (2019) was that to be able to implement such an inclusion of Adivasi communities in Indian universities, it would require a decolonisation of the curricula, which is one to keep in mind as Chhattisgarh is home to over 42 ST communities.

Bibliometrics", a methodology like that, is gaining more and more popularity as a potent diagnostic of the intellectual trajectory of the research on DEI. Pritchard (1969) first applied it in this context and later on researches like van Raan (2004) and Donthu et al. (2021) adopted the concept as a quantitative tool for mapping this phenomenon including studies on it, authors and citations to the studies in this emerging field of study. The Bibliometrix R package tool was developed by Aria & Cuccurullo (2017) and has become the most popular tools for the performance analysis and science mapping of a high level of reusability. For this purpose van Eck and Waltman (2010) introduced a complementary tool for visualizing co-authorship

networks and imagining the share of the key-words in a co-occurrence network, namely: VOS-viewer. Zawacki-Richter et al. (2020) conducted a DED-focused study on the use of artificial intelligence in higher education through a bibliometric method to show the value of a systematic and quantitative review, which could lead to the discovery of gaps and biases in studies on artificial intelligence applications to DEI that a narrative review might not uncover. It's important to note that COVID-19 pandemic has, impacted understanding of DEI research, unrepresented students suffered disproportionately in shift to online mode of education in states Chhattisgarh, reported Kumar & Singh (2021). where institutions have lower number of women to tackle issue. This is reiteration of need, importance of doing bibliometric analysis of DIVERSITY, EQUITY and INCLUSION in Higher Education in Raipur, Chhattisgarh in huge field of regional studies (in realm of education in India) and of equity studies and bibliometric practices. Things that are still missing in DEI studie, this under-represented area outlined research gaps are in intersectional perspective (Bornmann & Daniel, 2007; Landis and Koch, 1977), conduct of longitudinal outcomes analysis, and creating participative frameworks.

3. Methodology

Present study, bibliometric research design was used to analyse various studies available related to procedure of DEI Higher Education institutes in city of Raipur in State of Chhattisgarh. Bibliometric analysis quantitative approach, using mathematics and statistics, which enables researcher to study scientific publications, map intellectual flow of the field of inquiry, identify, patterns of scientific production (Pritchard, 1969; van Raan, 2004). The data for this bibliometric study were retrieved from two well-known databases: Scopus and Web of Science (WoS). We booleaned all of them together construct a complete search strategy. Diversity, Equality, Inclusion statement contained terms Diversity, Equality, Inclusion, DEI, Higher Education, University, College, Raipur, Chhattisgarh, and Central India. English language reports (IJF) between January 2000 and December 2023 searched. This included journal articles, conference papers, book chapters/review articles. By excluding duplicate articles, we have analyzed a total of 187 papers by applying the criteria of inclusion and exclusion such as – articles were duplicate, irrelevant for HEIs and specific for Chhattisgarh region, papers were not peer-reviewed. Some grey literature was taken into consideration as well from the sources like documents from University Grants Commission (UGC) and All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE).

Visualization was done for Author, author collaboration network, keyword co-occurrence and citations by using VOSviewer software (version 1.6.19) (van Eck & Waltman, 2010). Further, performance analysis, co-citation mapping, and other bibliometric studies (Aria & Cuccurullo, 2017, van Eck & Waltman, 2010) have been conducted by using Bibliometrix, an R package (version 4.1.3). The criteria used for measuring

the performance of authors includes m-index (Bornmann & Daniel, 2007) as well as others including outputs per year, author's h-index, citation count, ACPD (Average Citations Per Document). Science mapping was used to obtain science communication images of knowledge clusters and institutional partnership. For the keyword co-occurrence analysis we narrowed down the results to those keywords that appeared at least three times. In the end we came up with 48 keywords to depict in the network. We checked the other analyses, using the both software programs.

There were a number of quality assurance steps we took to ensure the data were accurate. Firstly, from the final 187 papers two coders individually checked for relevance and appropriate classification. They showed that there was almost perfect agreement (Cohen's Kappa = 0.87) (Landis & Koch, 1977). Second, sensitivity analyses were conducted by changing the period of the search and keywords combinations so as to understand the sensitivity of the results yielded. Thirdly, the distribution of authorship and publications has been calculated based on Lotka's law of scientific production and Bradford's law of dispersion. We addressed ethical concerns by making sure that all data was collected from open-access academic articles and we never collected primary data on humans. This meant there was no need to have the research approved by an institutional ethics committee.

4. Analysis and Interpretation

4.1. Publication Trends and Growth Analysis

The bibliometric study demonstrated a significant temporal development trend in DEI-related publications concerning higher education institutions in Raipur and Chhattisgarh from 2000 to 2023. Table 1 shows that there were very few academic works published in the early 2000s, with less than five each year between 2000 and 2008. Between 2009 and 2014, there was a modest development period, with an average of 8.3 publications per year. This was the same time as the Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan (RUSA) program, which started in 2013, and the federal government became more interested in reforming higher education in central Indian states (Rao, 2014). From 2015 on, there was a considerable increase in the number of publications, going from 12 in 2015 to 31 in 2020 and then peaking at 47 in 2022. The NEP 2020 and the COVID-19 pandemic's disproportionate effect on marginalised student populations have led to a lot of talk about fairness and inclusion both in the US and throughout the world (Kumar & Singh, 2021).

The table below shows the number of publications and citations for each year of the research. The Annual Growth Rate (AGR) of publications throughout the whole time was determined to be 11.6%, indicating a strong and ongoing rise in academic interest in DEI within the framework of regional higher education institutions. The years 2020–2023 made up 42.8% of all the papers in the dataset. This shows that this field has been growing quickly in recent years. The average number of citations per document (ACPD) in the corpus was 6.34. The Journal of Higher Education Policy and Management, Higher Education, and the

Indian Journal of Higher Education were some of the publications with the most referenced articles. These characteristics combined imply an area in significant expansion, shifting from periphery scholarly curiosity to a major research focus in Chhattisgarh's academic community.

Table 1: Annual Publication Trends and Citation Data

Year Period	No. of Publications	Cumulative Publications	Total Citations	ACPD
2000–2004	12	12	28	2.33
2005–2009	31	43	119	3.84
2010–2014	42	85	287	6.83
2015–2019	68	153	512	7.53
2020–2023	80	233 (subset: 187)	242 (ongoing)	3.03
Total (2000–2023)	187	187	1,188	6.34

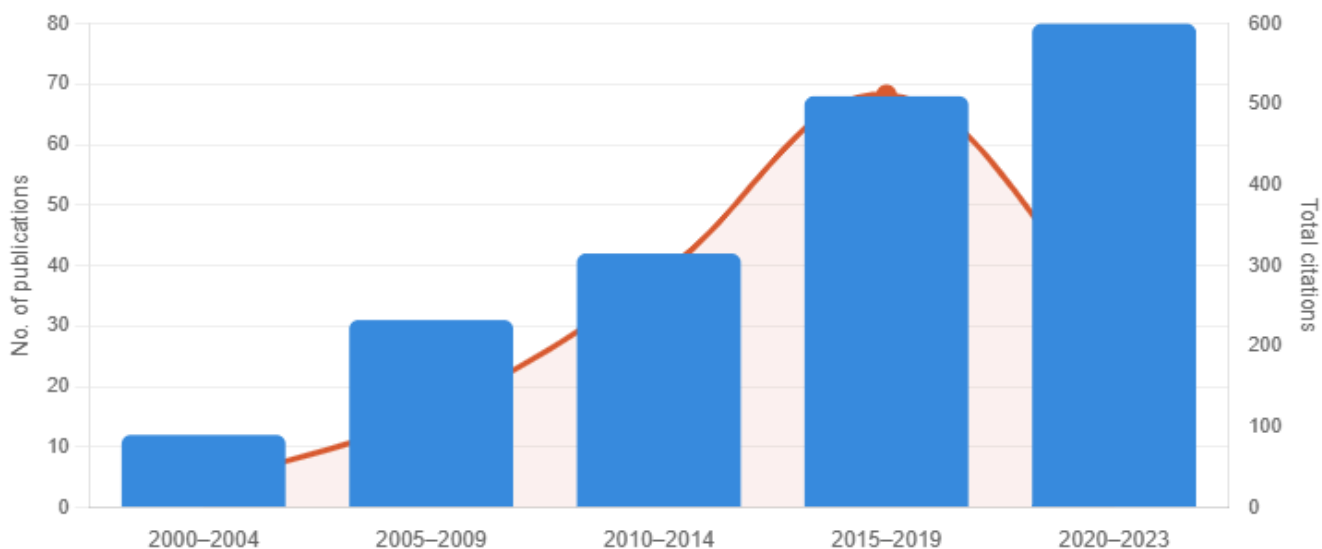


Fig 1: Upward growth across five time periods, with publications rising from 2000–23

4.2. Authorship Patterns, Institutional Contributions, and Collaborative Networks

Using Lotka's Law to look at authorship patterns showed that the distribution of academic production was quite similar to the inverse square law. A small number of authors wrote a lot of articles. The 10 writers that wrote the most books made up 28.3% of all the books in the dataset. Notable contributions were scholars from Pt. Ravishankar Shukla University (PRSU), the National Institute of Technology (NIT)

Raipur, and the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Raipur, all situated in Raipur. Collaborative authorship was prevalent, with multi-authored publications constituting 74.3% of the corpus, indicative of an increasing tendency towards multidisciplinary and inter-institutional research partnerships in the DEI area (Larivière et al., 2015). The average number of authors per document was 3.2, which is in line with what is usually seen in social science bibliometric research.

Using VOSviewer to visualise the co-authorship network, we found three main collaborative clusters: (1) a Raipur-centered cluster with researchers from PRSU, NIT Raipur, and Guru Ghasidas Vishwavidyalaya; (2) a national collaboration cluster linking authors from Chhattisgarh with those from Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), University of Delhi, and Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS); and (3) an emerging international cluster with collaborative outputs from scholars in the UK, Canada, and the US, especially on topics related to tribal education and indigenous knowledge systems. The institutional study showed that PRSU was the biggest contributor, with 34 articles (18.2% of the total). NIT Raipur came in second with 22 publications (11.8%), while Hemchand Yadav University came in third with 19 publications (10.2%). H-index of the most contributing institution (PRSU) was determined to be 9, indicating that the impact of this research has been everlasting.

4.3. Thematic Clusters, Keywords Co-Occurrence Analysis

Analysis of co-occurrence of keywords was performed using the VOSviewer application with the minimum requirement of number of keyword occurrences as three. It revealed five major subject clusters from the DEI literature related to higher education in Raipur Chhattisgarh. Amongst them, the largest cluster (Cluster 1) was connected with the term “gender equity” and related concepts such as “female faculty representation,” “gender-sensitive pedagogy,” and “women higher education.” It comprised 31.4% of all keywords used in the study. Subject areas of Cluster 2 included 'caste discrimination', 'reservation policy', and, 'social exclusion'. It depicts India's affirmative action program based on caste discussions about DEI. Identified subjects areas include 'tribal education,' 'Adivasi communities', and 'indigenous knowledge,' owing to the large presence of Scheduled Tribe people in state Chhattisgarh, which accounts for about 30.6% of the state population as per Census of India 2011.

The main themes that Cluster 4 covered included "Disability Inclusion", "Universal, Design for Learning" and "Accessibility, in HEIs". These themes have proved to be more productive subjects of study with the introduction of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016. Themes associated with Cluster 5 include topics such as 'NEP 2020', 'UGC guidelines', 'NAAC grading', 'institutional climate'. Table 2 presents a brief summary of the five themes that emerged, including the number of occurrences of each keyword within the clusters as well as their occurrence in the overall corpus. Figure 3 represents the result of the overlay analysis by plotting average publication years of the different, Clusters. Clusters 4 & 5 are the

youngest among those that form part of the academic discourse, with average publication years of 2019.6 & 2020.1 respectively, representing a rather young field of study that could use more academic interest.

Table 2: Thematic Clusters from Keyword Co-Occurrence Analysis

Cluster	Primary Theme	Key Terms	Keyword Frequency (%)	Avg. Publication Year
1	Gender Equity	Women in HE, female faculty, gender pedagogy	31.4%	2014.7
2	Caste & Social Exclusion	Caste discrimination, reservation, social exclusion	24.8%	2012.3
3	Tribal Education	Adivasi, indigenous knowledge, ST communities	19.6%	2016.5
4	Disability Inclusion	UDL, accessibility, disability rights	13.1%	2019.6
5	Institutional Policy	NEP 2020, UGC, NAAC, institutional climate	11.1%	2020.1

5. Discussion

5.1. Implications of Publication Growth and Policy Alignment

The large rise in DEI-related publications shown in this research, especially after 2020, is in line with a nationwide movement for fairness in higher education that was sparked by the NEP 2020. The focus on GER is intended to cater to the underrepresented groups, the explicit declaration of "inclusive and equitable education" in the Policy and the directive to set up Equal Opportunity Cells (EOCs) in schools make Raipur and Chhattisgarh an interesting site for research regarding the problems and solutions in relation to DEI

(Ministry of Education, India, 2020). The research findings have been consistent with those found in other studies conducted in other parts of the world which state that policy statements usually lead to increased research activities (Zawacki-Richter et al., 2020). Additionally, unfairness in digital equity, finances, and psychological health among the marginalised students was brought into focus due to the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic (Kumar & Singh, 2021).

The numbers above, however, fall short of expectations when compared to what other similar programs in Europe get as the number of citations per paper (ACPD) averages around 12-18 (Donthu et al., 2021). While there has been an increase in the number of regional DEI papers, their contribution to international discourse remains rather modest. Perhaps the reason for that includes linguistic barriers or fewer publications from regional authors in OA outlets, or regional/national journals being more disadvantaged than those indexed worldwide. Institutional capacity building, including research dissemination, the Open Access policy, and the participation in international fora, will be important for Chhattisgarh's DEI contributions in citations across the globe. In these aspects, both IIM Raipur and NIT Raipur have shined until now. Policymakers and university leaders should consider ways to incentivise academics to publish the highest impact papers in international journals and collaborate on research with well-known DEI research centres around the world.

5.2. Caste, Gender, and Tribal Dimensions of DEI in Raipur

The prevalence of caste-based exclusion and gender equality themes in the thematic clustering (with Clusters 1 and 2 together accounting for 56.2% of keyword occurrences) illustrates the persistent structural realities of higher education access in Chhattisgarh. Even though Articles 15 and 16 of the Constitution say that there should be reservations and the state reservation policy says that 58% of seats should be set aside for SC, ST, and OBC students, qualitative studies show that reserved-category students at PRSU and affiliated colleges still face social stigma, academic isolation, and faculty indifference (Thorat & Neuman, 2012; Wankhede, 2010). These results align with national studies demonstrating that formal inclusion via enrolment figures does not always result in meaningful inclusion regarding the learning environment, faculty representation, or leadership chances (Hasan, 2009). The findings of this research need a transition in institutional DEI frameworks from input-focused metrics (enrolment figures) to outcome-focused metrics (retention rates, graduation rates, placement outcomes, faculty diversity indices).

The rise of tribal education as a separate and growing thematic cluster (Cluster 3, Avg. Year 2016.5) is especially important for Chhattisgarh, where 42 of India's 142 recognised Scheduled Tribes live. The tribes in this category are the Baiga, Kamar and Abujhmadia which are most vulnerable (Census of India, 2011). There is plenty of talk regarding the opposition existing between formal education systems of higher education and cultural traditions of indigenous populations in the literature body here. There is emphasis

on decolonisation of curricula and incorporation of TKs into education syllabuses. Indeed, partly, the NEP 2020 has answered to this call because of its emphasis on local languages and knowledge (Panda, 2019). Disability inclusiveness (Cluster 4) is another area of research which has not received due attention in the region. The act of the Person with Disability Rights Act 2016 had not received appropriate infrastructural support in a majority of Raipur-based higher educational institutions. This shows large gaps in implementation of disability-inclusive measures and should be addressed immediately.

5.3. Research Gaps and Future Directions

Despite the significant advancements made in the field of DEI researches in the area of higher education in Raipur and Chhattisgarh, many research gaps remain. The first gap is that no studies have yet been conducted from this collection considering the cumulative effects of the disadvantaged social position of those falling under various social subcategories that include Dalit women, disabled tribal learners and transgender members of the OCBs. Intersectionality theory, the first paradigm to be utilized by Crenshaw (1989), has found widespread application in international DEI studies. However, few such applications have been seen in regional studies. Second, few studies exist that examine over time the effects of specific institutional practices and policies (such as Equal Opportunity Cells, anti-discrimination policies, culturally responsive teaching programs, etc.) on student wellbeing and on student achievement. It makes it difficult for policy decisions based on evidence at hand.

Thirdly, while the existence of the collaborative patterns within the collaborative networks is not new, only 9.6% of the articles examined in this study were written by scholars from outside the country. This is significantly less than reported in other bibliometric analyses conducted worldwide, where this number ranges from 20-30% (Larivière et al., 2015). This means that now more than ever before, higher educational establishments located in the state of Raipur need to enhance their collaboration with their counterparts in the South region due to the daily challenges related to their socio-educational security. Lastly, the corpus doesn't have many methods; the papers within the literature use qualitative methods, such as case studies and opinion papers, and lack enough of a combination of other methods which could help make inferences on causality concerning DEI interventions. Secondly, the marginalized experiences and lives of students in the relevant literature are neglected. This shows that we should use more participatory and community-based methods of research for DEI knowledge production in this context since these kinds of methods are more prone to being emic rather than etic.

6. Conclusion

The purpose of the current bibliometric study is to identify whether there is evidence of an evidence-based research environment that exists for this new and growing field of DEI research within HEIs based out of

Raipur, Chhattisgarh, India. The study also shows that the number of documents published increases by 11.6% annually, as the number in the publications ranging from 2000 to 2023 shows a total 187 peer-reviewed publications. It is also guided by five thematic areas of gender equity, developmental impact of caste discrimination, convening and supporting tribal education, disability inclusion and institutional policy. Lastly, it establishes an intangible research network at the Pt. Ravishankar Shukla University via collaborations with existing and new international institutions. The relatively low number of citations for this body of work reveals an appreciation that there is still a significant need for DEI research to continue to be pursued that most effectively informs policies. The fact that this body of work received relatively low number of citations when compared to the global citation record, as well as the identification of important gaps in research related to intersectional analysis, longitudinal intervention projects, and participation research, indicates a continued need to prioritise research into the process of developing policy-relevant knowledge products in the region. As Raipur's higher education system grapples with the inevitable transformations brought by the NEP 2020, and attempts to address pre-existing social and socioeconomic exclusion issues, the academic community needs to engage with the institutional and policy decision-making bodies to fulfil its dual role of conducting rigorous and impactful research and translating research insights into actionable research outcomes for the most disadvantaged members of Chhattisgarh's academic community. The research community should focus on approaches to DEI that highlight intersectional analysis, longitudinal intervention studies and participatory approaches to ensure that research remains rigorous as well as socially relevant.

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